QEVORIN PRESENTS

SMART MONEY

A Simple Guide to Budgeting, Saving, and Feeling More in Control

PLAN SMARTER. SAVE BETTER. LIVE WITH CONFIDENCE.

A practical, beginner-friendly workbook for building better money habits—one small step at a time.

DIGITAL EDITION • 2026

Published by Qevorin. Keep this guide nearby and revisit the worksheets each month.

Welcome

Managing money does not require a perfect salary, complicated spreadsheets, or extreme self-denial. It starts with knowing what comes in, deciding what matters, and giving your money a clear job.

This guide is designed to help you create a simple system you can actually maintain. Use the examples as starting points, then adjust them to your income, responsibilities, location, and goals.

What you will learn

- Build a budget that reflects your real life
- Track spending without feeling overwhelmed
- Choose a savings target and make it automatic
- Prepare for irregular expenses and emergencies
- Reset your plan when life changes

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All figures are illustrative. Use your own currency and local costs. This guide is educational and is not individualized financial, tax, or investment advice.

01 Start With Your Money Snapshot

Before changing your habits, understand your starting point. You do not need to judge every purchase. You only need a clear picture of the money moving through your life.

Step 1: Find your monthly take-home income

Use the amount you actually receive after taxes and payroll deductions. If your income varies, calculate a cautious baseline from several recent months rather than budgeting around your best month.

Step 2: List your essential expenses

- Housing and utilities
- Basic groceries and household supplies
- Transport
- Healthcare and insurance
- Minimum debt payments
- Childcare or family commitments

Step 3: Identify flexible spending

Look at dining out, subscriptions, shopping, entertainment, delivery fees, and other costs you can influence. Flexible does not mean bad. The goal is to decide which expenses are worth keeping.

Step 4: Calculate your current gap

Monthly gap = take-home income – **total monthly spending.** A positive number gives you room to save or pay down debt. A negative number signals that something needs to change—ideally through a combination of expense review, income improvement, and support where available.

Try this now

> **Write down your monthly take-home income, your three largest expenses, and one money question you want this guide to help you answer.**

02 Build a Budget You Can Maintain

A budget is a plan for your money, not a punishment. Start with a method that is easy to remember, then adapt it to your real costs.

A simple starting framework: 50 / 30 / 20

One popular framework allocates about 50% of take-home pay to needs, 30% to wants, and 20% to savings and extra debt repayment. It is a starting point—not a rule. If housing or essential costs are high, your percentages may look very different.

Category	Illustration on $2,000	Examples
Needs — 50%	$1,000	Housing, basic food, utilities, transport
Wants — 30%	$600	Eating out, hobbies, non-essential shopping
Savings / extra debt — 20%	$400	Emergency fund, goals, extra debt payments

If your essentials exceed 50%

Do not label yourself a failure. Prioritize housing, food, utilities, transport, healthcare, and required payments. Set a small realistic savings amount if possible, and look for changes that are safe and sustainable. A budget should reflect reality, not an ideal percentage.

Four steps to build your first budget

- Write down take-home income.
- Subtract fixed essentials and required payments.
- Set limits for flexible categories.
- Assign a savings amount—even a small one—before spending the remainder.

03 Track Spending Without Stress

You cannot make useful adjustments to spending you cannot see. Tracking does not have to mean recording every coin forever. Start with two weeks, then keep the method that works for you.

Choose one tracking method

- **Notes app:** record purchases in a few words each day.
- **Spreadsheet:** use columns for date, category, amount, and need/want.
- **Bank or budgeting app:** review categorized transactions and correct mistakes.
- **Cash envelopes:** set a weekly cash limit for a few flexible categories, where practical and safe.

The 10-minute weekly review

- Check your balances and recent transactions.
- Compare actual spending with your plan.
- Spot one surprise or repeat purchase.
- Choose one small adjustment for next week.

Use curiosity, not guilt

Instead of saying, “I am bad with money,” ask, “What made this purchase happen?” Was it convenience, stress, an unexpected need, or a subscription you forgot? Understanding the trigger helps you design a better system.

Mini spending log

Date	Item	Amount	Need / Want

04 Make Saving a Habit

Saving works best when it is a repeatable action rather than a decision you make only when money is left over.

Give every savings goal a name

“Save more” is vague. “Build a $300 emergency buffer” is specific. Name each goal, set a target amount, and decide when you want to reach it. Break the target into weekly or monthly steps.

Use the pay-yourself-first approach

When income arrives, move a realistic amount to savings before discretionary spending. If possible, automate a transfer to a separate savings account. Keep enough accessible money for bills and avoid fees or overdrafts.

Example: a small goal adds up

Saved each week	Approx. after 12 weeks	Approx. after 52 weeks
$5	$60	$260
$10	$120	$520
$25	$300	$1,300

Figures exclude interest and assume the same amount is saved each period.

Build momentum in stages

- Start with a small starter buffer you can reach soon.
- Work toward an emergency fund that covers essential costs for a period suited to your circumstances.
- Create separate funds for predictable future costs such as annual insurance, school expenses, travel, or repairs.
- If you have high-interest debt, compare the cost of that debt with the value of building a basic cash buffer; a balanced plan may be more sustainable than an all-or-nothing approach.

The best savings amount is one you can repeat without missing essential bills.

05 Prepare for Emergencies and Irregular Costs

A budget can look balanced until a car repair, medical bill, family need, or annual fee appears. These costs feel sudden, but some can be anticipated.

Separate emergencies from predictable expenses

Emergency: an unexpected, necessary cost, such as an urgent repair or an income interruption.
Irregular but expected: a yearly bill, school supplies, seasonal travel, or routine maintenance.

Create sinking funds

A sinking fund is money set aside gradually for a known future expense. Estimate the cost and divide it by the number of pay periods remaining. For example, a $240 annual bill can be funded by setting aside $20 each month.

Build a starter emergency buffer

Choose a first milestone that is meaningful in your own currency and situation. It could be enough to cover one urgent repair, a week of essential costs, or another realistic amount. Once that milestone is reached, decide whether to grow it further.

Where should the money live?

For money you may need quickly, prioritize safety, access, and low fees over chasing high returns. Consider a suitable regulated deposit account in your country, and understand any withdrawal limits, deposit protections, and currency risks.

If money is already tight

Focus first on immediate essentials, contacting providers early if you may miss a payment, checking eligibility for local assistance, and avoiding expensive borrowing where possible. If you are facing persistent hardship, seek qualified local support.

06 Reduce Spending Without Feeling Deprived

A sustainable budget leaves room for enjoyment. The aim is to spend more intentionally—not to remove every pleasure from your life.

Try these low-friction changes

- **Pause before buying:** wait 24 hours for non-urgent purchases; use a longer pause for expensive items.
- **Audit subscriptions:** cancel or downgrade services you rarely use.
- **Plan meals and errands:** reduce last-minute spending where practical.
- **Compare recurring bills:** review phone, internet, insurance, and service plans when renewal comes around.
- **Use a shopping list:** decide what you need before entering a store or opening an app.
- **Keep a fun-money category:** a planned amount can reduce the feeling of constant restriction.

Try a 3-question purchase check

- Do I need this now, or can it wait?
- Does it fit the money I have available after essentials and goals?
- Would I still choose it tomorrow?

A practical example

Imagine you spend $18 each week on small impulse purchases. Reducing that by one-third frees about $6 per week, or roughly $312 over a year. You do not have to eliminate the purchases entirely; a modest change can still create useful breathing room.

Protect what matters

Do not cut essential medication, adequate food, safe housing, or necessary transport simply to meet a target. Look for flexible costs first, and seek advice if your essentials are unaffordable.

07 Your 30-Day Money Reset

Use this four-week plan to move from awareness to action. You can repeat it whenever your circumstances change.

WEEK 1 — Observe

- Write down take-home income and fixed bills.
- Review recent transactions.
- List debts, minimum payments, and due dates.
- Choose one financial goal.

WEEK 2 — Plan

- Set realistic limits for flexible categories.
- Choose a savings amount you can sustain.
- Identify annual or irregular expenses.
- Make a simple bill calendar.

WEEK 3 — Adjust

- Cancel or change one low-value recurring expense.
- Plan one lower-cost alternative to a regular purchase.
- Set up a savings transfer if safe and practical.
- Check whether any bill needs early attention.

WEEK 4 — Review

- Compare your plan with actual spending.
- Celebrate one useful change.
- Adjust unrealistic categories without guilt.
- Choose the next month's savings target.

Your monthly money meeting

Choose one day each month to spend 15–20 minutes reviewing income, upcoming bills, savings progress, and any changes ahead. Put it on your calendar. Consistency is more valuable than a complicated system you rarely use.

> **Remember: one month is a beginning, not a final exam. The system should evolve as your life evolves.**

Tool 1 Monthly Budget Worksheet

Fill in the blank spaces using your own currency. Use estimates first, then update them when you have real numbers.

MONTHLY INCOME	Planned	Actual
Take-home income		
Other reliable income		
TOTAL INCOME		
ESSENTIAL EXPENSES	**Planned**	**Actual**
Housing		
Utilities / phone / internet		
Groceries / household		
Transport		
Healthcare / insurance		
Debt minimums		
Family / other essentials		
FLEXIBLE SPENDING	**Planned**	**Actual**
Dining / coffee		
Shopping		
Entertainment / hobbies		
Subscriptions		
Other flexible spending		
Savings / extra debt repayment		
MONEY LEFT (or shortfall)		

Quick calculation: Total income – essentials – flexible spending – savings/extra debt payments = money left (or shortfall).

Tool 2 Weekly Check-In & Goal Planner

Use this page once a week. Keep it short enough that you will actually do it.

Weekly check-in

Question	My notes
What went well with money this week?	
What cost more than I expected?	
Which purchase felt worth it?	
What is one change for next week?	

My savings goal

Goal	
Target amount / currency	
Current amount saved	
Amount to save each week or month	
Target date	
First small action	

A promise to myself

“I will focus on progress, not perfection. I will review my plan regularly and make changes when my real life requires them.”

Your Next Step

You do not need to fix everything today. Choose one action that makes your money easier to understand or manage, and complete it within the next 24 hours.

Pick one

- Review the last 30 days of transactions.
- Write a list of upcoming bills and due dates.
- Cancel one unused subscription.
- Set a small, realistic savings target.
- Schedule a 15-minute weekly money review.

The core principles

- Give your money a plan before it is spent.
- Track enough to learn, not to judge yourself.
- Automate saving when your cash flow allows.
- Plan for both emergencies and predictable irregular costs.
- Adjust your budget as your life changes.

> **Small steps, repeated consistently, can create more clarity and confidence over time.**

Thank you for reading **Smart Money**. Keep this guide nearby and revisit the worksheets at the start of each month.

Disclaimer

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